

Why should I Photoshop?

While Photoshop is *de facto* for professionals, you've probably even used it at home for basic tasks like resizing images, and maybe even a few effects here and there. The idea behind Photoshop is to bring these effects to anyone who wants them, not just the people in the business. So whether it's cleaning up those old holiday snaps or creating your own artwork, there's nothing that Photoshop can't let you do.

1.2 Getting Started

You're going to need quite a respectable machine before you start Photoshopping, but your final configuration will rest on what you really want to use it for. As a hobbyist, you'll probably do fine with anything over a Pentium III and around 384 MB of RAM—just like Adobe recommends, but a Pentium 4 with 512 MB of RAM should provide you with a smoother, more satisfying experience. If you want to use Photoshop for more intensive purposes such as creating and editing graphics for print, you should have at least 1 GB of RAM, though you should still be able to get what you want with 512 MB as well. Of course, your PC will start screaming in agony sooner than it should. Photoshop tries to load as much of the image as possible into system memory, so the general rule of thumb is that if you work with big images, you should get big memory to make everything run quick. Effects like filters require some serious number-crunching capabilities, so do take a little out of that piggy-bank for a higher-end processor (preferably a dual-core) if you're going to dabble in some professional, high-end special effects.

Preferences

Before you begin anything in Photoshop, it's a good thing to tweak a few options that will make it work better for you.

To get to the Preferences dialog, go to Edit > Preferences > General, or hit [Ctrl]+[K].